ATOMIC SECRETS · A GYR-O SITE

Atomic Secrets · the hidden history of nuclear weapons

WHAT THIS IS

Two contested stories from the atomic age, told with every source in view. One is the 1944 Port Chicago explosion, which the journalist Peter Vogel spent thirty years arguing was a secret nuclear test. The other is Yoichi Shimatsu's reporting on hidden weapons sites in Fukushima after 2011.

The claims here are their authors'. The official accounts are set beside them, so you can weigh both.

the new front door to atomic-secrets.org · November 2026

THE PAGE LAYOUT BELOW IS STANDARD ON EVERY GYR-O SITE

A PLAIN ANSWERS ✓

– What is this site?

It is the new front door to **atomic-secrets.org**[14], the site Walter Wilkinson has run since 2024 on two stories the official histories tell differently.

- **Port Chicago, 1944.** An ammunition pier near San Francisco blew up and killed 320 men. The Navy called it an accident. Peter Vogel argued it was a test of an early atomic bomb.
- **Fukushima, 2011.** After the earthquake and tsunami, the science writer Yoichi Shimatsu reported that secret weapons laboratories in northern Japan were part of what was destroyed.

The old site stays online, unchanged, as an archive. This page is where to start.

– What happened at Port Chicago?

On the night of July 17, 1944, two explosions destroyed the loading pier at the Port Chicago Naval Magazine on Suisun Bay, along with two ships and a train[1]. **320 men were killed and about 400 injured.** Most of the dead were Black enlisted sailors, who did the loading under white officers.

When the survivors were ordered back to loading weeks later, 50 refused and were convicted of mutiny[2]. On the 80th anniversary, July 17, 2024, the Navy exonerated all 256 men court-martialed after the disaster, finding serious legal errors in their trials.

A Navy Court of Inquiry sat for 39 days. It listed possible causes, from rough handling to sabotage, but named none as proven[3]. The site is now a national memorial[4].

– What did Peter Vogel claim?

That the Port Chicago explosion was a **proof test of an early nuclear weapon**, a year before the first acknowledged test at Trinity in July 1945. His summary identifies it as a low-efficiency implosion design, the "Mark II".

His search began in the spring of 1980, with a Los Alamos document he says he bought at a church rummage sale, titled *History of the 10,000 Ton Gadget*. He published the idea in *The Black Scholar* in 1982, and posted a full book online in 2001[5].

This is a minority view. The Navy's record and the standard histories treat the disaster as a conventional explosion of munitions. Column C sets out what Vogel offered as evidence, and where it is open to question.

– Where is Vogel's book now?

Vogel's own website went dark in 2018. His book survived only as chapter files deep in the Internet Archive[5], where Walter Wilkinson found it in October 2024. He merged the chapters, added a table of contents and published it in 2025 as a Kindle book[6]. A revised 2026 edition is in preparation.

Vogel himself was not heard from in public after April 2019. He died in Brooklyn on December 27, 2022, at 83; his estate was administered in the Kings County Surrogate's Court[15].

– Is there a film of the explosion?

Vogel said there was. In 1981, he reported, the base's public affairs officer told him the Navy held a nitrate film of the blast, which would date it before about 1950. The Navy later called its film a Hollywood-style re-creation, made in the 1960s. **No copy has been found.**

Vogel described the film in a 1999 radio interview[7]. A 1980 KQED television documentary he says used parts of it is being retrieved from the University of Georgia's Peabody archive.

– Who else has worked on Port Chicago?

Daisy B. Herndon, whose 2022 book *American Nuclear Deception*[8] argues that the explosion must be investigated as a nuclear event. She is the only author who says she corresponded with Vogel. Her book adds material his does not, including the argument that President Roosevelt witnessed the explosion.

– What is the Fukushima story here?

Yoichi Shimatsu, a Japanese-American science writer living in northern Japan in 2011, was, by his account, the first journalist to enter the exclusion zone around the stricken Fukushima Daiichi plant with a camera. In a 2018 video[9] he visits nine places he says secretly housed underground weapons laboratories, some destroyed on March 11, 2011. He argues they, not only the reactors, explain the radiation released.

The archive keeps his articles from rense.com[10] and pages on individual sites, such as Kido Dam, which he says produces no power.

These are his claims. The official investigations attribute the releases to meltdowns at three Fukushima Daiichi reactors after the earthquake and tsunami knocked out their cooling[11]. Japan did run a wartime atomic program[12]; there is no public record of postwar weapons laboratories.

– Who is behind it?

Walter Wilkinson, a retired engineer in Worland, Wyoming, who edited and published the surviving edition of Vogel's book and has spoken about Port Chicago four times on Jeff Rense's radio program[13].

– How do I read the old site?

Go to atomic-secrets.org[14]. Every page, picture, recording and download stays where it was, so links in the books and in old posts keep working. Only the discussion forum and the reader logins have gone.

B SOURCES ✓

HOW TO READ A CARD

Every card below reads the same way, top to bottom. Parts 4 and 5 are the ones a bare footnote never gives you.

1. **Number and kind** — what sort of thing it is
2. **Title** — what it is called
3. **Provenance** — who made it, when, under what license
4. **Preview** — what you would find if you went there
5. **Why it is cited** — what it is doing on this page
6. **The link** — last, and only last

INTERNAL LINKS

Most recent content change.

> **6 November 2026 — Vogel's death found; the site opens**
> atomic-secrets.online goes up as the front door to atomic-secrets.org, which is kept as an archive.

EXTERNAL LINKS

Every reference to some other website.

1 RECORD · OFFICIAL

Port Chicago Naval Magazine Explosion

Naval History and Heritage Command · U.S. Navy

The Navy's own history of the disaster: the loading pier, the ships SS E.A. Bryan and SS Quinault Victory, the casualties, and the Court of Inquiry that sat for 39 days from July 21, 1944.

Why it is cited: for the basic facts of the night, in the Navy's words.

→ history.navy.mil · Port Chicago

2 RECORD · OFFICIAL

The Secretary of the Navy Exonerates 256 Defendants

U.S. Navy press release · July 17, 2024

Announces the full exoneration of the 256 men court-martialed after the explosion, including the Port Chicago 50 convicted of mutiny, after the Navy's General Counsel found they were tried together despite conflicting interests and denied meaningful counsel.

Why it is cited: for the 2024 exoneration and its reasons.

→ navy.mil · press release 3841792

3 PRIMARY DOCUMENT

Court of Inquiry: findings, opinion and recommendations

Navy Department Library · online documents

The Court's findings of fact and its opinion, which ranked possible causes by probability, among them a supersensitive element, rough handling, failure of handling gear and sabotage, without settling on one.

Why it is cited: because the official cause was never determined, which is the gap Vogel's theory sets out to fill.

→ history.navy.mil · online documents

4 PLACE

Port Chicago Naval Magazine National Memorial

National Park Service

The memorial at the site, inside the Army's Military Ocean Terminal Concord. Visits are by reservation.

Why it is cited: for anyone who wants to see the place.

→ nps.gov/poch

5 ARCHIVE · PRIMARY

Peter Vogel's last website, as saved

Internet Archive copy of petervogel.us · September 26, 2017

Vogel's own pages for *The Last Wave from Port Chicago*, with the chapter files. The site and every chapter file were last changed on February 9, 2016; the address shows a parking page by October 2019.

Why it is cited: it is the book in its author's own presentation.

→ web.archive.org · petervogel.us

6 BOOK

The Last Wave from Port Chicago, 2025 edition

Peter Vogel, edited by Walter Wilkinson · Kindle

Vogel's book recovered from the Internet Archive, with the chapters merged and a table of contents added.

Why it is cited: it is the only edition of the book you can buy.

→ amazon.com/dp/B0F9XNCP78

7 RECORDING

For the Record #444: Peter Vogel

Dave Emory, KFJC radio · recorded February 1, 2004 · part 1 of 2

Vogel on air about the Gadget document, returning it to the government, and the film of the explosion.

Why it is cited: his own voice on the claims in column A.

→ emory.kfjc.org · f-444a.mp3

8 BOOK

American Nuclear Deception

Daisy B. Herndon · 2022

Argues that "the Port Chicago experiment" must be investigated, and adds the argument that Roosevelt witnessed it.

Why it is cited: the main work on the subject after Vogel's.

→ amazon.com/dp/B0BFW3DFQ8

9 VIDEO

Tracking Fukushima's Nuclear Weapons Sites

Yoichi Shimatsu · 2018 · about 20 minutes

Shimatsu's visits to nine places in northern Japan he identifies as former underground weapons laboratories.

Why it is cited: the source of the Fukushima claims in column A.

→ youtube.com · o_a4UUGsUQ4

10 ARTICLES

Underground Warhead Labs of Northern Japan

Yoichi Shimatsu · rense.com

Shimatsu's written account of the sites, which the archive's Fukushima pages summarize and illustrate.

Why it is cited: his claims in his own words.

→ rense.com/general96/warhead.html

11 REFERENCE

Fukushima nuclear accident

Wikipedia

The standard account: after the March 11, 2011 earthquake and tsunami cut power to the cooling systems, three reactors at Fukushima Daiichi melted down and released radioactive material.

Why it is cited: the official version, set beside Shimatsu's.

→ en.wikipedia.org · Fukushima nuclear accident

12 REFERENCE

Japanese nuclear weapons program

Wikipedia

The wartime atomic research of the Imperial Army and Navy, which ended with the defeat in 1945.

Why it is cited: for what is on the record about atomic work in Japan.

→ en.wikipedia.org · Japanese nuclear weapons program

13 FILES

The cover-up of the 1944 Port Chicago atomic explosion: files

rense.com · mirror of Vogel's research archive

About sixty files Vogel gathered alongside his chapters, mirrored at rense.com for safekeeping.

Why it is cited: the research archive behind the book, kept in a second place.

→ rense.com · Port Chicago files

14 ARCHIVE · THIS SITE'S OWN

atomic-secrets.org

Walter Wilkinson · 2024 to 2026 · kept as an archive

The original site: about a hundred pages on Port Chicago, Peter Vogel, Daisy Herndon and Yoichi Shimatsu's Fukushima reporting, with recordings, slide decks and downloads.

Why it is cited: everything summarized on this page is there at length.

→ atomic-secrets.org

15 COURT RECORD

Estate of Peter Vogel, also known as Robert Lance Vogel

Kings County Surrogate's Court, Brooklyn · file 2023-2443

The estate file opened in April 2023: an administration proceeding, with no will, giving the date of death as December 27, 2022. Search by name in Kings County to see the file history.

Why it is cited: the only public record of Vogel's death that has been found.

→ websurrogates.nycourts.gov · Kings County, file 2023-2443

C DETAILS ✓

The Port Chicago record

The explosion came at about 10:18 p.m. on July 17, 1944, while sailors loaded the Liberty ship SS *E.A. Bryan* at the depot's pier, with the new SS *Quinault Victory* moored alongside[1]. Two blasts a few seconds apart were felt across the bay. The Court of Inquiry convened on July 21 and sat for 39 days[3]; its findings ranked six possible causes and settled on none. Fifty sailors who refused to resume loading in August were convicted of mutiny that autumn, before the Court's report was final, a point the Navy's 2024 review counted against the trials[2].

Vogel's case, and its weak points

Vogel's argument rests on four kinds of evidence, each set out in his book[5]:

- **The Gadget document.** A Los Alamos table of bomb effects, one line of which reads, in his account, "ball of fire mushroom out at 18,000 feet in typical Port Chicago fashion." He showed it to Edward Teller in August 1980 and later returned it to the government, which confirmed in writing that it was genuine.
- **Eyewitness descriptions** of a white flash and a rising cloud, rather than the orange fire expected from burning munitions.
- **The film** described in column A, and the Navy's changing account of it.
- **The paper trail:** records he says were reclassified after he asked for them, and Manhattan Project figures connected to the investigation.

Where it is open to question. Authenticating a document is not the same as authenticating Vogel's reading of one line in it. Eyewitness accounts of large explosions vary widely. No radiation survey has shown fallout from the blast: the one amateur survey Vogel cited, in 2004, found raised readings on one road that its own author called unverified. And no film has been produced. The 2026 edition's new introduction takes these points one by one.

What happened to Vogel's work

- **1982** — article, "The Last Wave from Port Chicago", in *The Black Scholar*.
- **2001** — the book goes online at portchicago.org as PDF files, one for each of 16 chapters and three appendices.
- **February 9, 2016** — last change to petervogel.us and its chapter files; three days later, his only Facebook post about the book.

- **December 2018** — last archived copy of his site with content; by October 2019 the address is parked.
- **April 1, 2019** — his last Facebook post. After that the trail goes cold.
- **December 27, 2022** — Vogel dies in Brooklyn, at 83. No obituary was published; the record is the estate file in the Kings County Surrogate's Court[15].
- **October 2024** — Walter Wilkinson recovers the chapters, and about sixty other files, from the Internet Archive[13].
- **July 20, 2025** — the Kindle edition[6].

The Fukushima pages

Shimatsu's 2018 video[9] and his rense.com articles[10] are the source for the archive's Fukushima section. The archive adds pages on individual places, among them Kido Dam, the Haramachi power station and the Vemork heavy-water plant in Norway, offered for comparison, plus AI-generated slide decks of his material. Against them stand the official accounts of the reactor meltdowns[11].

The archive at atomic-secrets.org

In November 2026 the original WordPress site was copied, page by page, to a frozen static copy at the same address[14]: about a hundred pages and nine hundred files. Every address stays the same, so links printed in the books still work. The forum and the reader logins were not carried over.

Forty-nine files were already missing from the live site when it was copied. Thirty-one were recovered from the Internet Archive. Eighteen are lost, among them the banner for the lost-film page and an early PDF of the book.

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